Ryan Giggs and Tom Brady are sportspeople in other disciplines who push me towards it, showing me what's possible. British runner Jo Pavey, too, had a second child at 40 and still competed in the Commonwealth Games. If she could do that, I could keep going. Some people think age determines how we behave and what we can do. I start to realise that it isn't the case and, as I watch teammates every year retire through injury or lack of form, I begin to treat it like a duty to myself, of a commitment back to cricket too, to not think about the end of my career from a legacy perspective or as something to get through, but to keep going, keep pushing, keep playing, keep hold of the thing I had dreamed up and miraculously came true, until either I couldn't get on the field or it would turn its back on me.

In the off season, before a series begins, I take on more training than I have ever done. The work happens before the cricket even comes into view. I do weights in the gym on Monday, Wednesday and Friday. I work on my arms, legs and core. It's tough, repetitive and arduous work, where I have to remind myself every morning that wickets are on the other side of it, somewhere down the line. On Tuesday, Thursday and Saturday I am doing a mixture of shuttle sprints, between 40, 50 and 60 metres. Then some longer distance running between 3 and 7 km. In between all of that is interval training, either four minutes running and two minutes off or two minutes on and one minute off or one minute on, one minute off, all done on the running track. I swim a couple of times a week. I load all this into my body daily, thinking about the cricket simultaneously, visualising who I will be bowling at and how I will get them out so that when it comes around, I just have to unlock what is already inside.